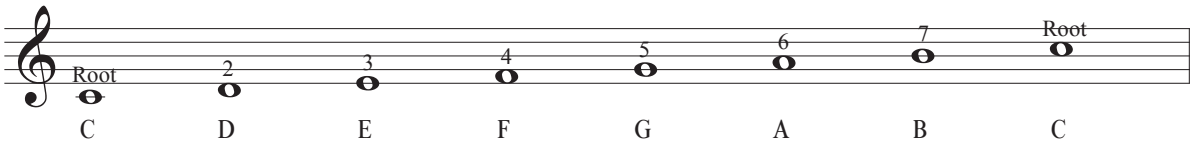
Chordal Components

C Major Add and Extended Chords

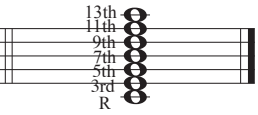
Stefon Harris

C(add 2)

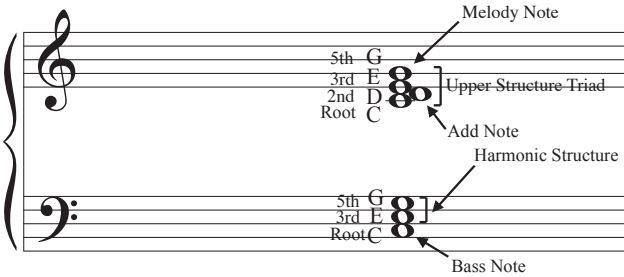
Scale Degrees



Harmonic Stack

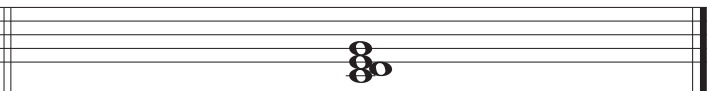


Chordal Components

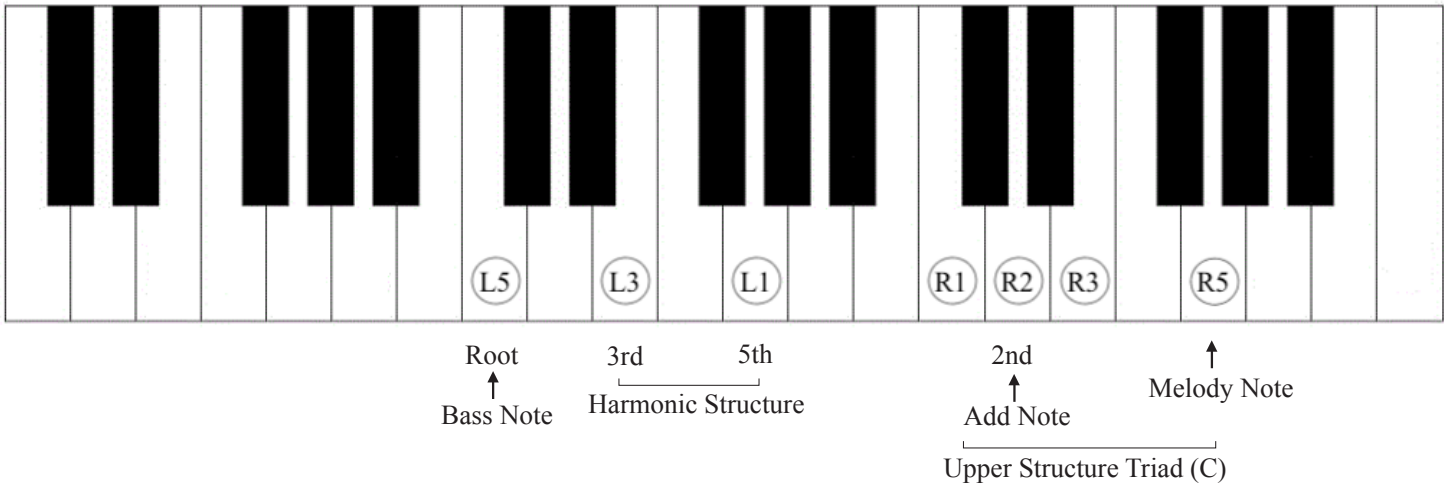


Piano Voicing

C(add 2) Ⓒ / C(add 2) (2R) or I(add 2)



Piano Voicing



Emotional Description:

Gesture:

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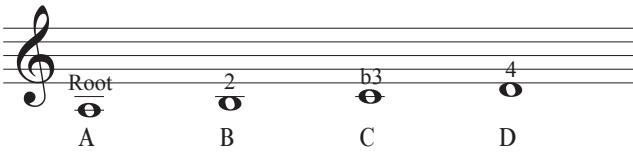
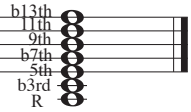
A-7(add b6)

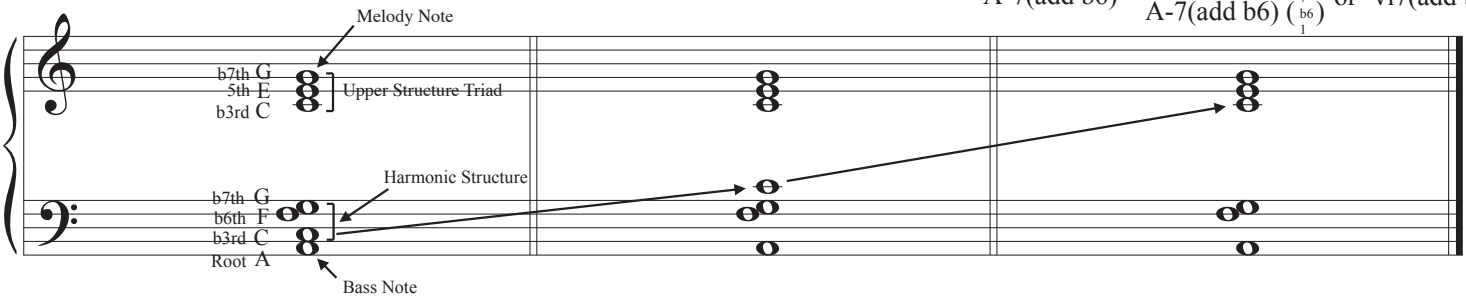
Scale Degrees



Harmonic Stack



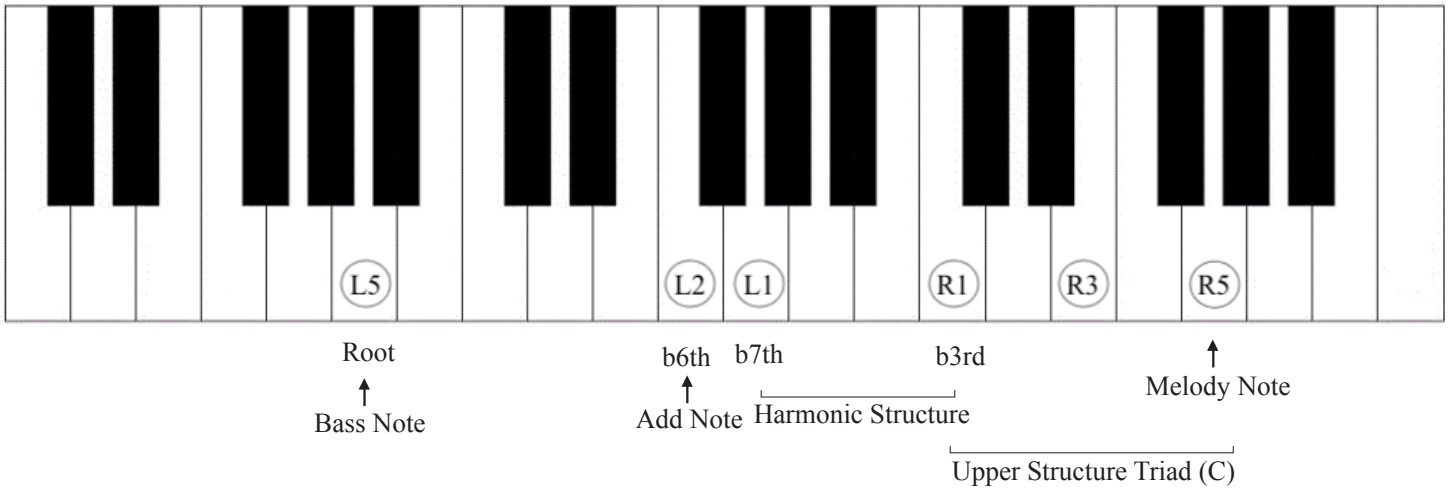
Chordal Components



Piano Voicing

A-7(add b6) $\frac{\text{C}}{\text{A-7(add b6)}}$ $\binom{7}{b6}{1}$ or vi7(add b6)

Piano Voicing



Emotional Description:

Gesture:

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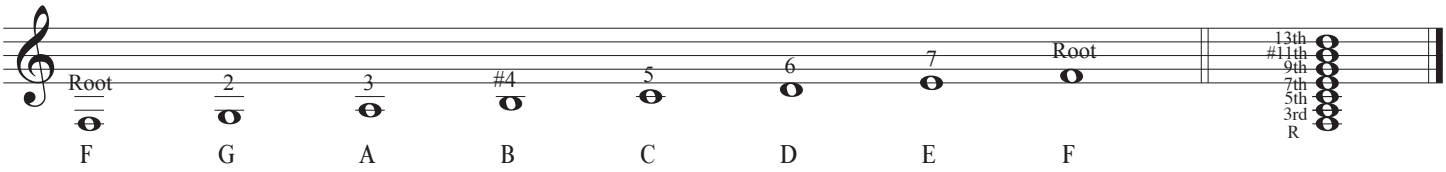
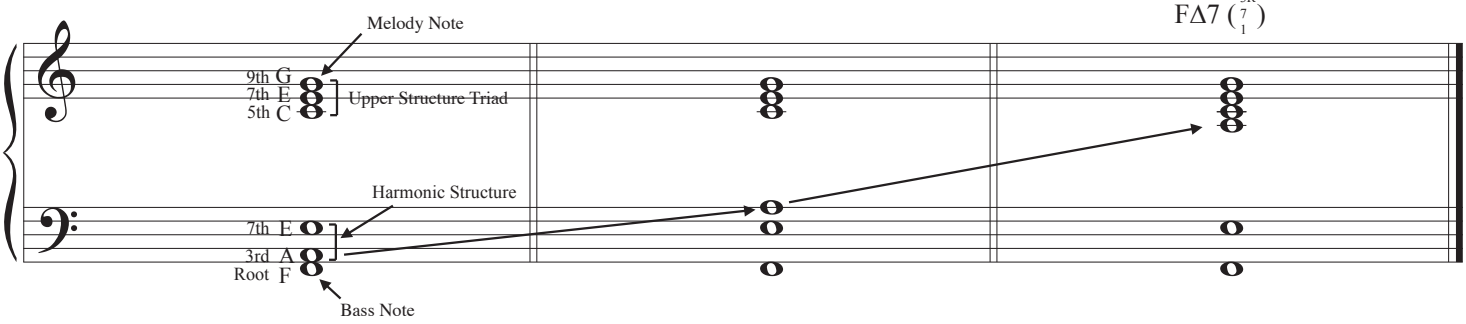
FΔ9

Scale Degrees **Harmonic Stack**

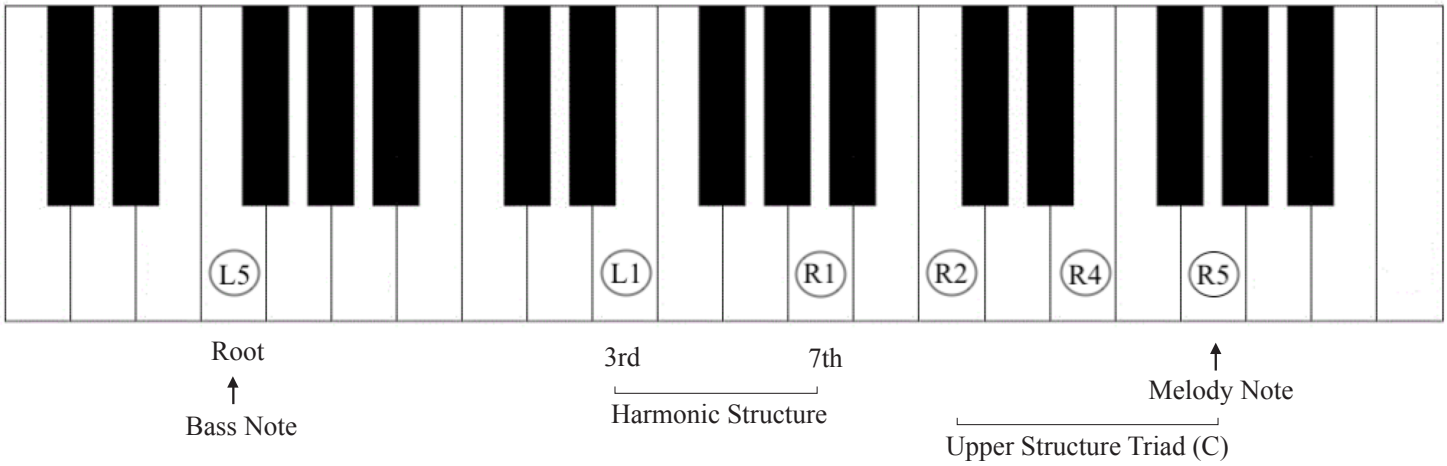


Chordal Components **Piano Voicing**

FΔ9 Ⓒ / FΔ7 (3R 7 1) or IVΔ9



Piano Voicing



Emotional Description:

Gesture:

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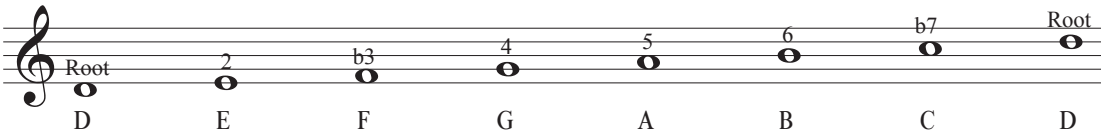
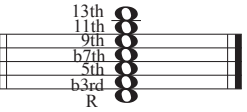
D-11(9)

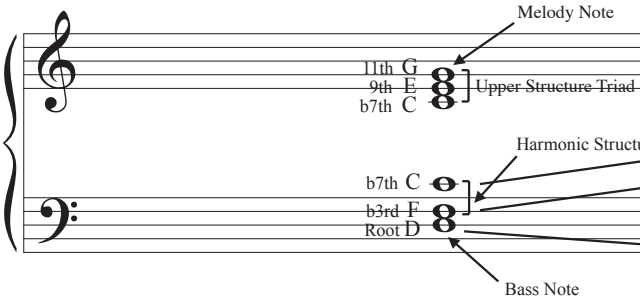
Scale Degrees



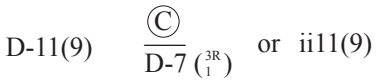
Harmonic Stack



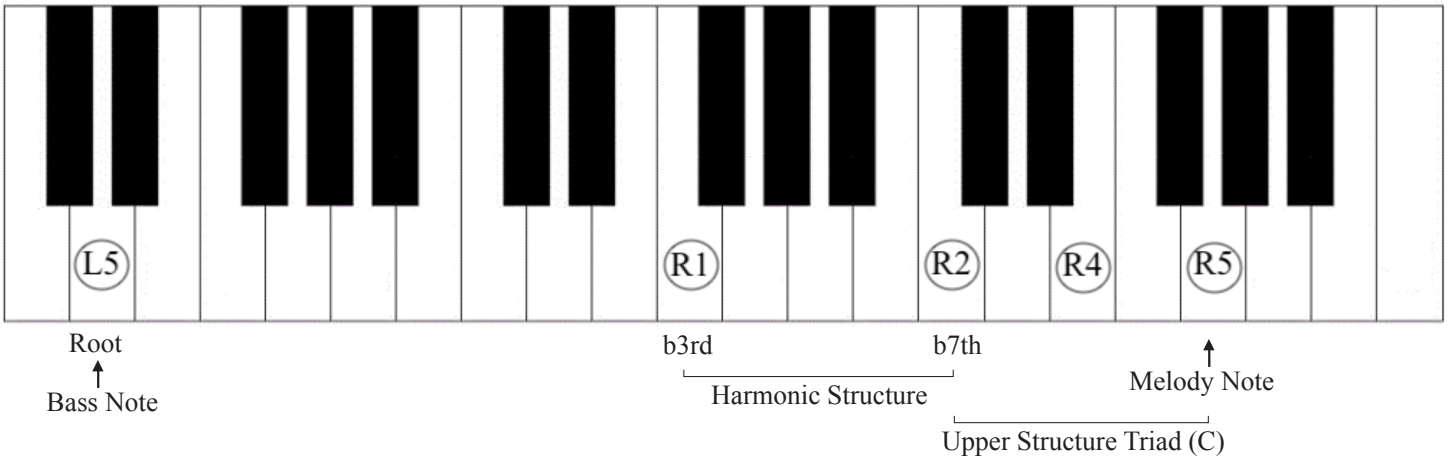
Chordal Components



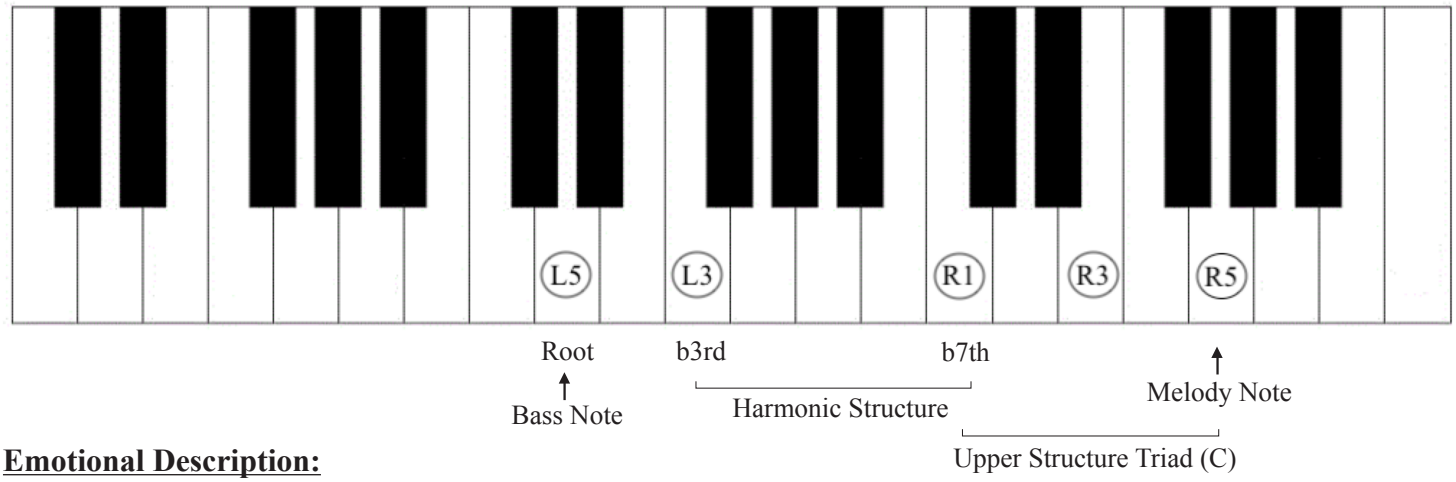
Piano Voicing



Piano Voicing #1



Piano Voicing #2



Emotional Description:

Gesture:

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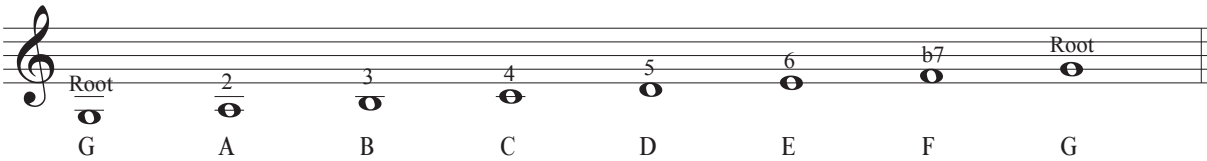
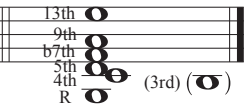
G13sus(add 9)

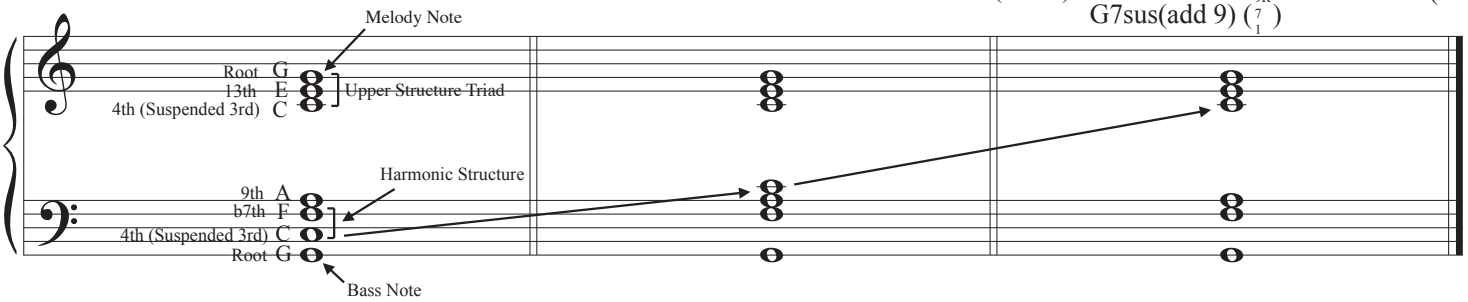
Scale Degrees



Harmonic Stack



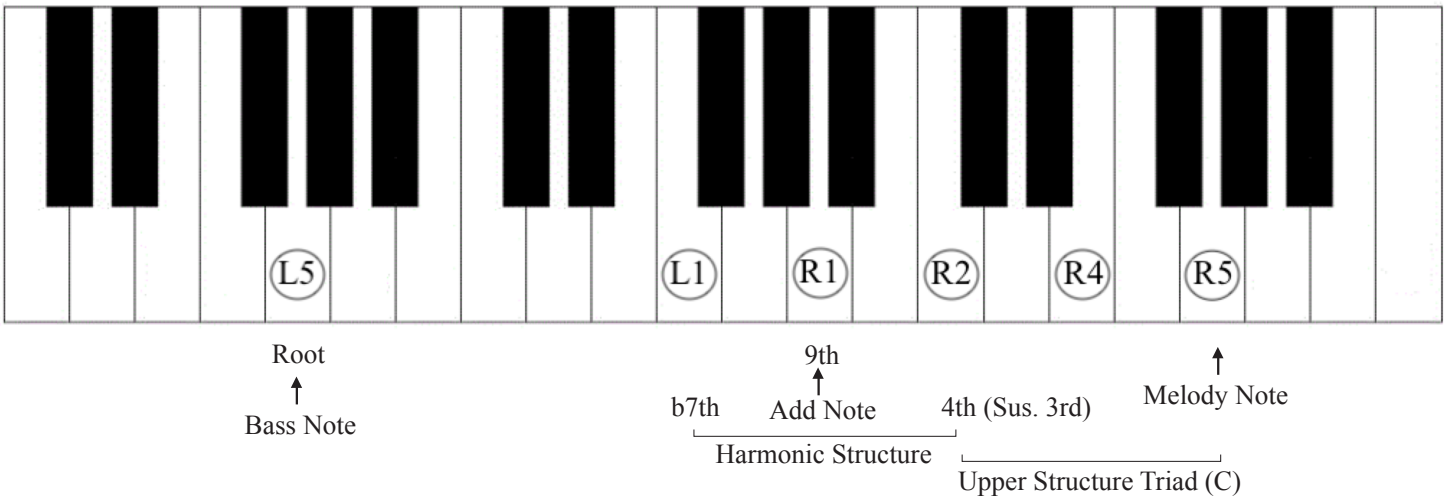
Chordal Components



Piano Voicing

G13sus(add 9) $\frac{\text{Ⓒ}}{\text{G7sus(add 9)}\ (^{9R}_{7\ 1})}$ or V13sus(add 9)

Piano Voicing



Emotional Description:

Gesture:

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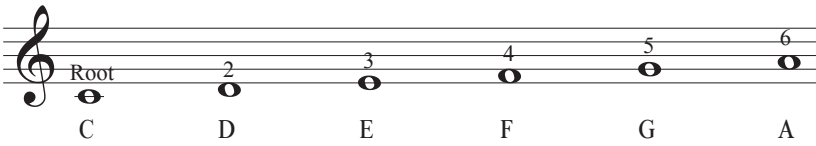
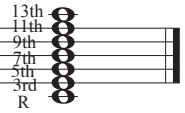
C(add 2)/E

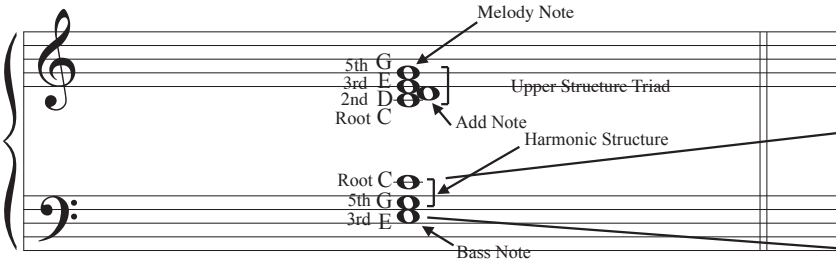
Scale Degrees



Harmonic Stack

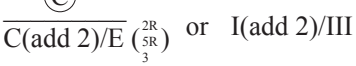


Chordal Components

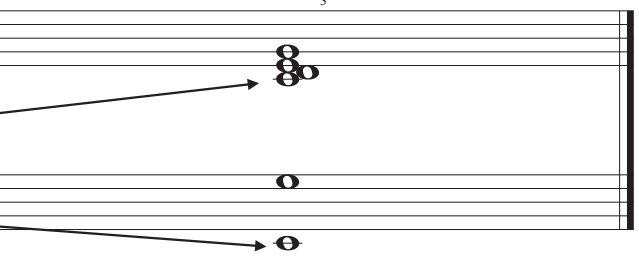


Piano Voicing

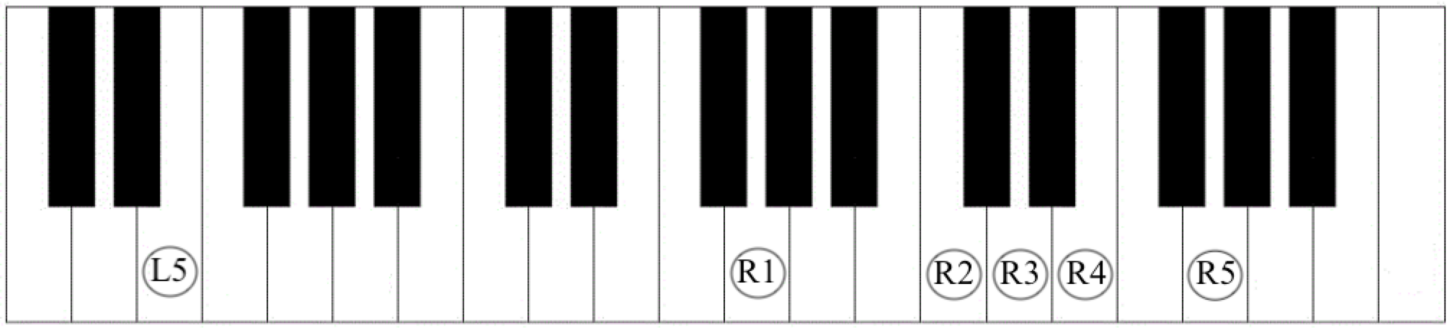
C(add 2)/E



or I(add 2)/III



Piano Voicing



3rd
Bass Note

5th Root
Harmonic Structure

Melody Note

Upper Structure Triad (C)

Emotional Description:

Gesture:

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Piano Diagram Fingering System

L = Left Hand
R = Right Hand
1 = Thumb
2 = Index
3 = Middle
4 = Ring
5 = Pinky

Examples:
L5 = Left Hand Pinky
R2 = Right Hand Index Finger

Scale Degrees

Root = 1st scale degree
# = Raise scale degree by a half step
b = Lower scale degree by a half step

Chordal Components

There are four components to every chord:
1) *Melody Note*
2) *Upper Structure Triad*
3) *Harmonic Structure*
4) *Bass Note*

- When properly arranged, these four components create a harmonious voicing.

Harmonic Structures

- A "Root Position Triad" contains the Root (1) in the bass and the 3rd and 5th in the *Harmonic Structure*.

- A "1st Inversion Triad" contains the 3rd in the bass and the Root (1) and 5th in the *Harmonic Structure*.

- "Major 7th" (Δ7), "Minor 7th" (-7), and "Dominant 7th" (7) chords have the Root in the bass and the 3rd and 7th in the *Harmonic Structure*. The *Harmonic Structure* does not need to include the 5th.

- "7sus" chords contain the Root (1) in the bass and the 4th (suspended 3rd) and 7th in the *Harmonic Structure*. The *Harmonic Structure* does not need to include the 5th.

Add Notes

- *Add Notes* cannot be on the top part of the voicing (*Melody Note*). They are usually added in the middle/lower part of a voicing and are never duplicated.

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Voicings

- Generally, the *Melody Note* and *Upper Structure Triad* are played in the Right Hand and the *Bass Note* and *Harmonic Structure* are played in the Left Hand.

- If a note in the *Upper Structure Triad* is duplicated in the *Harmonic Structure,* play the duplicate note/notes in the Right Hand only.

- To avoid creating voicings that are too low and unclear, sometimes notes from the *Harmonic Structure* are transposed up an octave (see *Low Interval Limits* PDF) although one must also keep in mind that sometimes transposing those notes up an octave can create wide intervals that are not playable in the Left Hand alone.

- If the intervals are too large to play in the Left Hand alone, the higher notes of the *Harmonic Structure* can be played in the Right Hand along with the *Upper Structure Triad*.

Tips on How to Get Comfortable with a Piano Voicing

1) Pick a voicing to practice.

2) Begin by holding the keys down and taking a mental picture of the shape. Take as much time as necessary to visually memorize the shape of the voicing.

3) Lift your fingers off the keys slightly. Look away for a second and then look at the piano again and play the voicing.

4) Take your hands completely off the piano, look away, and then turn back and play the voicing again. Repeat this step several times until you are very comfortable playing this voicing.

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